an ingrained respect for rules and norms. Certainly, this is the self-image, which itself is a powerful motivation. Through its actions and messaging, India has patiently created the narrative of a responsible democratic power. Few would contest that this is anything but a net asset to a world uncertain of its future directions. But there is also the fact that the evolution of the Indian polity has brought out its societal characteristics more sharply than before. As it begins to define itself more clearly, there would be an inevitable period of argumentation and adjustment. Debates generated by the political developments of the last year indicate that this process won't be easy. At the end of the day, it will all be about rebalancing, as that is what nationalism in global affairs is hastening.

At the core of a contemporary compact with the West is the need for an appreciation of the changes in our country. This will require an acceptance that an elite created in a Western mould has now outlived its relevance. Looking beyond orthodoxies is more widely accepted now and the Munich Security Conference 2020 tellingly focused on 'Westlessness'. For its part, India must make the most of this concern while developing a nuanced understanding of the Western world. It is now values and strategy that could bring India and the West together, rather than habits and culture. How effectively that would happen will be one of the factors shaping the global landscape.